MOREH NEVUCHIM

Place & Throne: What Makom & Kisei Really Mean

Given Tuesday 30 June 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 8–9

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapters 8 & 9 **Topic:** The Terms מקום (Makom / Place) and כסא (Kisei / Throne) in Tanakh **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Where We Are in the Moreh

Chapters	Theme
1–4	Incorporeality — verses implying corporeality (tzelem, temunah, seeing God)
5	Caution approaching the divine (Moshe at the burning bush)
6–7	Ma'aseh Bereshit — Ish/Isha (form & matter); Ben (birthing & the power of a teacher)
8–9 (tonight)	**Back to incorporeality** — terms that *seem* to imply God has physicality: **Makom** (place) and **Kisei** (throne)

PART 1 — Chapter 8: The Term מקום (Makom / Place)

The Two Meanings of Makom

Meaning 1 — Physical Space (the literal meaning)

ועיקר קריאת מונח זה היא למקום מיוחד או כללי **physical space.**

- **Meyuchad (specific)**: "He's sitting in this house, on this chair, in this room"
- **Klali (general)**: "He's in this neighborhood / this city"

Either way — the literal *makom* is the physical space something occupies.

Meaning 2 — Status / Rank (a borrowed, conceptual sense)

ולאחר מכן הורחבה משמעותו... והפך למונח לדרגת האדם ומעלתו It was **broadened to denote a person's status and level** — his standing in a particular subject.

"פלוני במקום פלוני בנושא פלוני" — X is at *place* X in subject X (e.g., "which *place* are you up to in the Gemara?" — a *conceptual* place, not geographical)

- The Gemara: **ממלא מקום אבותיו** — one who "fills the place of his fathers" — i.e., follows them **בחכמה ובירא** (in wisdom and fear), not a geographical spot
- The Mishnah: **ועדיין המחלוקת במקומה עומדת** — "the debate still stands in its place" — i.e., in its *status* (במעמדה), not a physical location

This conceptual usage exists in other languages too: in English, *"I'm not in a good place today"* — not a geographical statement, but about one's mental/emotional **status**. The same borrowing happens in Hebrew.

Applying It — "Baruch Kevod Hashem MiMekomo"

said **four times a day** (before Shema, in Kedusha, in Uva Letzion, and — (Yechezkel) **ברוך כבוד ה' ממקומו** at Mincha)

This does **NOT** mean "blessed is Hashem from the [physical] place where He is" — Hashem is not in a specific place (that would imply limitation/corporeality).

It means: according to His level and supreme standing in כלומר לפי דרגתו וגודל חלקו במציאות **existence** — His conceptual "place," which is **incomparable / sui generis** (אין שווה לו ולא דומה לו).

Word by word: *Baruch* (blessed) · *Kevod Hashem* (God's glory — either God Himself, or those who recognize His glory) · *mimkomo* (from His "place" = His unique conceptual standing in all of reality).

The whole point of the chapter: so you don't fall into thinking Hashem occupies a specific place — which would imply corporeality and limitation. His "place" is a unique conceptual standing, because nothing is comparable to Him.

A Crucial Aside — This Book Is NOT a Lexicon

דע שכל מונח שאנו מבארים לך בחיבור זה... אין מטרתנו בכך להאיר את מה שנזכר בו בלבד, אלא אנחנו פותחים בכך שער

Rambam's purpose isn't merely to define words. Each word's explanation is a **key (מפתח)** — opening gates to understand *all* the places that term appears across Tanakh and Chazal, **for our philosophical purpose**, not for linguistic interest.

Once you learn this book, **go** ואתה תתבונן בספרי הנבואה... ותבין כל מונח רב משמעי במשמעות המתאימה לו **back and study Tanakh again** — now reading each multi-meaning term in its proper context. **Our words .are a key to this work and others**

Applying It Again — "Hinei Makom Iti" (Ki Tisa)

After the golden calf, Moshe asks **הראני נא את כבודך** ("show me Your glory"). Hashem responds:

"Behold, there is a *place* with Me, and you shall stand on the rock" — **הנה מקום אתי ונצבת על הצור**

.this means **a level of intellectual contemplation** — not a physical eye/place — דרגת עיון והתבוננות השכל
this is *in addition to* the simple meaning that there was a — זאת בנוסף למקום בהר... שבו הייתה התבודדות .physical spot on the mountain

The deeper meaning: *Makom* here = a **rank**. Hashem tells Moshe: "You asked to see My glory; I cannot give you the whole, but I will raise you to **a new intellectual place** (conceptual understanding of Me) you've never reached before."

A Key Methodological Principle (will recur often)

Rambam does NOT remove the literal meaning unless there is a need to do so. Here the verse *still* literally means a physical place on the mountain — *and also* carries the deeper meaning of an intellectual ascent.

Rashi on This Verse

הנה מקום אתי — *peshat*: "there is a place prepared for your need where you'll stand and behold what you behold": (sheltered so you won't be harmed). *Midrash* Hashem says — **המקום אתי ואינו אומר אני במקום** "the place is *with Me*," not "I am *in* a place" — because **הקדוש ברוך הוא מקומו של עולם ואין עולמו מקומו**. **God is the "place" of the world; the world is not His place.**

The Gemara (Berachot 7a)

At this moment, Moshe also asked Hashem to explain **צדיק ורע לו, רשע וטוב לו** — why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper. He didn't receive a full answer — but it shows this was an **intellectual encounter** and an opening for philosophical inquiry, confirming *makom* here is a **conceptual** place.

Developing the Concept — Makom in Other Places

1. "Ayeh Mekom Kevodo" (Keter / Musaf)

His glory fills the world, and His ministers ask:" **כבודו מלא עולם, ומשרתיו שואלים: איה מקום כבודו להעריצו** "*?where is the place of His glory, to revere Him*

Not "where geographically is God?" — rather: **where is the intellectual space to grasp Him?** How can any creation — even angels — comprehend God's glory and presence?

The drawn-out "Ayeh" (Sephardi / Arizal custom): the old Iraqi and Syrian custom of extending *ayeh* (sometimes for a full minute — the highlight of Shabbat morning). The likely reason: as we say *ayeh*, we are **straining to attain an intellectual conception of Hakadosh Baruch Hu** — *where, how, can we reach this?*

The Arizal on the Yamim Nora'im: there are **four** times we say *ayeh* (Rosh Hashanah Day 1 Musaf, Day 2 Musaf, Yom Kippur Musaf, Ne'ilah). At each, pray for **one** of three things only: (1) Ruach Hakodesh/prophecy, (2) parnasah, (3) righteous children. *(One custom: choose differently for the first three; the fourth — what you choose — defines what you most want in life.)* A beautiful link: as we conceptualize Hashem (*ayeh*), we draw near to prophecy, to becoming good role models (→ righteous children), and to recognizing all comes from Hashem (→ parnasah).

2. "HaMakom" as a Name of Hashem

ברוך המקום ברוך הוא (Pesach Haggadah); **המקום ינחם אתכם בתוך שאר אבלי ציון וירושלים** (Ashkenazi consolation)

Why is Hashem called "HaMakom"? Simply: because **He is the "place" of the entire universe** — His presence sustains all existence (as Rashi said). *(Per Rambam's chapter, one could add: because His standing is sui generis — incomparable — He is "the Place.")*

The Gematria (attributed to the Vilna Gaon): the **square** of the Name 100 = $5^2 + 6^2 + 5^2 + 10^2$) **186** = יקוק (186 = 25 + 36 + 25 +. And 186 = 40 + 6 + 100 + 40 = **המקום** (with the *kollel*). The two are equal.

Why this matters (via the Ramchal, Da'at Tevunot) — why Ashkenazim say "HaMakom yenachem" at a shiva: יקוק is Hashem's Name of **mercy** — but its mercy is **not always recognized** in life (we see much that seems to contradict it). The *square* represents the Name **fully manifested / drawn out**. When does a person most question Hashem's mercy? **When losing a loved one** (when *middat hadin* is most apparent). So we bless them: **HaMakom yenachem** — *may the Name of mercy (יקוק) be fully squared, manifested, and felt in your life* — that you not only know theoretically that יקוק is mercy, but actually experience it, and so be comforted.

3. Makom in the Akeidah

Four times in a short span:

וילך אל **המקום** אשר אמר לו האלהים · וירא את **המקום** מרחוק · ויבאו אל **המקום** · ויקרא אברהם שם **המקום** ההוא ה' יראה

Abarbanel (500 years ago) cites those who argued — *based on this very Rambam* — that because *makom* can mean a conceptual place and is stressed four times, the **Akeidah never physically happened** (only in a vision).

Abarbanel demolishes this. The Akeidah **physically happened** — two real people, Avraham and Yitzchak, saddled a donkey and traveled. As Rambam himself taught (on *hinei makom iti*), **one removes the literal meaning only when there is a necessity** — a logical or scientific problem. Here there is none. The emphasis on *makom* teaches that **through this process they ascended to new intellectual levels** — it's *both* a physical place *and* a conceptual ascent.

4. The Makom of Gan Eden (to be developed later)

Was Hashem placing Adam in Gan Eden a **physical/geographical** space — or a **heightened intellectual space** to understand God, from which he was banished after the sin? *(Raised here as something to think about; to be revisited later in the book.)*

Chapter 8 Summary

Makom means (1) a specific/general **physical space**, or (2) a **rank/conceptual standing**. Hence: *Baruch kevod Hashem mimekomo* = according to His incomparable conceptual standing; *hinei makom iti* = an intellectual ascent (while still literally a spot on the mountain). Applied further: *ayeh mekom kevodo* (where is the intellectual space to grasp Him), *HaMakom* as a Name (He is the place of the world), the Akeidah (physical *and* an ascent), and Gan Eden (to come).

PART 2 — Chapter 9: The Term כסא (Kisei / Throne)

Meaning 1 — A Chair / Throne (the literal meaning)

קביעותו העיקרית בלשון היא שמו של הכיסא **seat**.The primary meaning is a

Crucial linguistic point: In Hebrew there is **no separate word** for "chair" vs. "throne" — *kisei* is both. Why? Because **a chair was once a luxury** — ordinary people sat on the ground; only the great had seats. *(Modern Hebrew now needs both because everyone has chairs.)*

וכיון שעל הכיסא היו יושבים רק בעלי הרוממות והגדולה כמו המלכים... והכיסא נעשה לדבר המורה גדולתו של מי שראוי לו **Since only the eminent (kings, dignitaries) sat on a seat, the seat became an indicator of the importance of the one who sits on it.**

Meaning 2 — Something of Importance/Majesty (borrowed sense)

Because the seat denotes importance, *kisei* is borrowed for **important things**:

The Temple Is Called "Kisei"

> The **Mikdash** is called a נקרא המקדש כיסא... כיון שהוא מורה על גדולתו של מי שהתגלה בו והשרה את אורו throne because it indicates the greatness of the One whose holiness rests there **כסא כבוד מרום מראשון**. "Throne of glory, exalted from the beginning, the place of our Temple" — (Yirmiyahu) **מקום מקדשנו**.

The Heavens Are Called "Kisei"

> The **heavens** (the entire celestial order נקרא השמים כיסא... משום שהם מורים... גדולתו של מי שיצרם ומנהיגם — galaxies, celestial bodies) are called a throne because, to one who understands them, they display the greatness of their Creator. Yeshayahu — Haftarah of Shabbat Rosh) **השמים כסאי והארץ הדום רגלי** The heavens are My throne, the earth My footstool." I.e., **they indicate My existence**" — (Chodesh **My greatness, and My power to sustain them** — just as a throne indicates the importance of **,(מציאותי)** the one fit for it.

Rambam highly valued astronomy and astrophysics (the paths and composition of celestial bodies) as genuine *chochmah* through which one apprehends God — while **rejecting astrology** (the claim that celestial bodies influence humans), as he makes clear in his letters.

A supporting proof (Rabbi Kada — surprised Rambam didn't cite it): Pharaoh to Yosef — **רק הכסא אגדל ממך** ("only by the throne will I be greater than you," Miketz). This is **not** a bigger physical chair — it means **"only in importance will I exceed you."** *Kisei* = importance, not merely a physical seat.

The Principle Stated

> **NOT that there is a body upon which** לא שיש גוף שהאלוה שוכן עליו... כי עוד יתבאר לך שהוא יתעלה אינו גוף **God sits** — for He has no body; so how could He have a place (Ch. 8) or a throne? Rather, **any place Hashem glorified and singled out with His light** — like the Mikdash or the heavens — is called *kisei*.

This runs against the Midrash (Bereishit Rabbah 1:4) that the **Kisei HaKavod** was one of the things preceding creation — which Rambam must either reinterpret or not accept.

A Stylistic Observation (Rabbi Kada) — How Rambam Teaches

Most people give a *drasha* by: quote the verse → raise a question → give the answer → "from here we learn." **Rambam consistently does the opposite.** He **first lays the foundations** ("what does *makom*/*kisei* mean generally?"), and only then brings the verse — so you are **led naturally** to the conclusion rather than starting "on the back foot" with a problem. A more elegant mode of delivery: **build the lesson, then discover it in the Torah.**

Meaning 3 — Kisei as God Himself (the verse in Beshalach)

After Amalek:

> and he said: *for there*..." **כי יד על כס יה**, מלחמה לה' בעמלק מדור דור, ויאמר: ויבן משה מזבח ויקרא שמו ה' נסי *is a hand upon the throne (kes) of God* — Hashem has war with Amalek in every generation."

Why neither Meaning 1 nor 2 fits: It can't be a *physical* throne (God has no body); and "something important" doesn't fit the sentence either. So what does *kes Yah* mean here?

מה שהלשון הרחיב בו... הרי הוא תיאור גדולתו ורוממותו... שאין ראוי לדמיין שום דבר מחוץ לעצמותו ולא נברא מנבראיו It is **a description of God's own greatness** — and one must **not imagine anything outside His essence.**

כך שיתעלה נמצא בלי כסא ונמצא עם כסא — **זו כפירה בלי ספק** To imagine God *sometimes with* a throne and *sometimes without* — **is outright heresy.**

כבר נאמר במפורש: **אתה ה' לעולם תשב, כסאך לדור ודור** — "*Your* throne is for all generations, Hashem, dwell forever; *Your* throne is for all generations" — (Eicha) showing **the throne is not distinct from God.** — **מה שמורה שהוא דבר שלא נדמהו ממנו**

ולפיכך הכוונה בכסא... תפארתו וגדולתו שאינו חוץ מעצמותו **Therefore "kisei" here means God's own splendor and greatness — not something outside His essence.**

The Underlying Principle — The Unity of God

God's **absolute unity** forbids speaking of an attribute as *separate* from Him. With a human we say "X is wise, handsome, generous" — three things X *has* and could lose. **This cannot apply to God:** His unity demands everything is included in the One. So one cannot speak of "the throne of Hashem" as though there were Hashem *and* His throne — even conceptually — because that would imply *sometimes a throne, sometimes not*. **Rejected on philosophical grounds.**

So the Verse Means:

Moshe swears by raising his hand — *kisei Yah* = **Hashem Himself**. Raising the hand always signals an oath (cf. Eliezer: **וישם העבד את ידו תחת ירך אברהם... וישבע**). So **כי יד על כס יה** = Moshe lifts his hand in an oath upon Hashem Himself. *(This is unlike Onkelos, who reads it differently — for another time.)*

Chapter 9 Summary — The Three Meanings of Kisei

1. **A physical seat/throne** (literal)
2. **Something majestic/important** — the Mikdash, the heavens (which display God's greatness; cf. *rak hakisei egdal mimcha*)
3. **God Himself** (in *kes Yah*) — because the unity of God forbids treating "His throne" as anything distinct from His essence

A doorway to later study: this prepares us to understand the visions of **Yechezkel and Yeshayahu** "seeing Hashem on an elevated throne" — i.e., a deep intellectual apprehension of God's majesty, not a literal seated figure.

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 8 — Makom

- **Two meanings:** physical space (specific/general) · conceptual rank/status
- *Baruch kevod Hashem mimekomo* = His incomparable conceptual standing; *hinei makom iti* = an intellectual ascent (while still literally a place — **remove peshat only when necessary**)
- The book is **a key, not a lexicon** — apply each term across Tanakh
- Developed: *ayeh mekom kevodo* · **HaMakom** as a Name (gematria 186; the consolation formula) · the Akeidah (Abarbanel: physical *and* an ascent) · Gan Eden (later)

Chapter 9 — Kisei

- **Three meanings:** a seat/throne · majesty/importance (Mikdash, heavens) · **God Himself** (*kes Yah*)
- Rooted in the **unity of God** — no attribute or "throne" is separate from His essence
- Rambam's elegant method: **lay foundations first, then reveal the verse**

Coming Up Next Week

Chapters 10 (and possibly 11): the terms for **standing and sitting, ascending and descending** — what these motions mean when applied to the divine.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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